French Fries from Talking With

By Jane Martin

INTRODUCTION

Forget the Seven Wonders of the World. Globally, the Golden Arches are surely the most infamous man-made landmark. For over 50 years, more consumers have chosen McDonald's as the site of their McConsumption than any other fast food chain. With over 25,000 restaurants worldwide, McDonald's has certainly achieved an overwhelming presence. Could we live without McDonalds? Oh sure, we say we could live without Micky D's, but when push comes to shove we've all got Big Mac on the mind. Come on, admit it, you want one right now don't you? Meet Anna Mae . . . she's attached to McDonald's and here's why. . . French Fries from Talking With by Jane Martin.

She is an old woman in a straight-back chair holding a McDonald's cup. She is surrounded by several bundles of newspapers. She wears thick glasses that distort her eyes in the viewer.

ANNA MAE: If I had one wish in my life, why I'd like to live in McDonald's. Right there in the restaurant. 'Stead of in this old place. I'll come up to the brow of the hill, bowed down with my troubles, hurtin' under my load and I'll see that yellow horseshoe, sort of like part of a rainbow, and it gives my old spirit a life. Lord, I can sit in a McDonald's all day. I've done it too. Walked the seven miles with the sun just on its way, and then sat there on the curb till vie minutes of seven. First one there and the last to leave. Just like some ol' French fry they forgot.

I like the young people workin' there. Like a team of fine young horses when I was growin' up. All smilin'. Tell you what I really like

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though is the plastic. God gave us plastic so there wouldn't be no stains on his world. See, in the human world of earth it gets all scratched, stained, tore up, faded down. Loses it's shine. All of it does. In time. Well, God gave us the idea of plastic so we'd know what the everlasting really was. See if there's plastic then there's surely eternity. It's God's hint.

You ever watch folks when they come on in the McDonalds? They always speed up, almost run the last few steps. You see if they don't. Old Dobbin with the barn in sight. They know it's safe in there and it ain't safe outside. Now it ain't safe outside and you know it.

I've seen a man healed by a Big Mac. I have. I was just sittin' there. Last summer it was. Oh, they don't never move you on. It's a sacred law of McDonald's, you can sit for a hundred years. Only place in this world. Anyway, a fella, maybe thirty five, maybe forty, come on in there dressed real nice, real bright tie, bran' new baseball cap, nice white socks and he had him that disease. You know the one I mean, Cerebral Walrus they call it. Anyway, he had him a cock leg. His poor old body had it two speeds at the same time. Now he got him some coffee, with a lid on, and sat him down and Jimmy the tow-head cook knew him, see, and he brought over a Big Mac. Well, the sick fella ate maybe half of it and then he was just sittin', you know, suffering those tremors, when a couple of

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ants come right out of the burger. Now there ain't no ants in McDonald's no way. Lord sent those ants and the sick fella he looked real sharp at the burger and a bunch more ants marched on out nice as you please and his head lolled right over and he pitched himself out of that chair and banged his head on the floor, loud. THWACK! Like a bowling ball dropping. Made you half sick to hear it. We jump up and run over but he was cold out. Well those servin' kids, so cute, they watered him, stuck a touch pepper up his nostril, slapped him up right smart, and bang, up he got. Standin' an' blinkin'. .Well how are you, we say. An' he looks us over, looks tight in our eyes, and he says, I'm fine.. And he was. He was fine! Tipped his Cincinnati Reds baseball cap, big, jus' swallowed the canary grin, paraded out of there clean, straight like a polebean poplar, walked him a plumb line without no trace of the walrus.. Got outside, jumped up, whooped, hollered, sang him the National Anthem, flagged down a Circle Line bus, an' rode off up Muhammad Ali Boulevard wavin' an' smilin' like the King of the Pharaohs. Healed by a Big Mac. I saw it.

McDonald's. You ever see anybody die in a McDonald's? Nor sir. No way. Nobody has ever died in one. Shoot, they die in Burger Kings all the time. Kentucky Fried Chicken's got their own damn ambulances. Nooooooooooo, you can't die in a McDonald's no matter how hard you try. It's the spices. Seals you safe in this life like it seals in the flavor. Yesssssssss, yes!

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I asked Jarrell could I live there. See they close up around ten, and there ain't a thing goin' on in 'em till seven A.M. I'd just sit in those nice swingy chairs and lean forward. Rest my head on those cool, cool, smooth tables, sing me a hymn, and sleep like a baby. Jarrell, he said he'd write him a letter up the chain of command and see would they let me. Oh, I got my bid in. Peaceful and clean.

Sometimes I see it like the last of a movie. You know how they start the picture up real close and then back it off steady and fat? Well, that's how I dream it. I'm living in McDonald's and it's real late at night and you see me up close, smiling, and then you see the whole McDonald's from the outside, lit up and friendly. And I get smaller and smaller, like they do, and then it's just a light in the darkness, like as star, and I'm in it. I'm part of that light, part of the whole sky, and its all McDonald's, but part of something even bigger, something fixed and shiny. like plastic.

I know. I know. It's just a dream. Just a beacon in the storm.
But you got to have a dream. It's our dreams make us what we are.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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